

Subjectless assumption in Japanese *-te aru* configuration*

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Abstract: There are two main types of *-te aru* configurations in Japanese: the intransitivizing and non-intransitivizing *-te aru*. For the intransitivizing *-te aru*, it is essential to further verify and clarify the (non-)existence of the agent and its syntactic nature. This article investigates the argument structure of the intransitivizing *-te aru*, aiming to determine whether there is a covert agent in the structure through subject-oriented adverbs. By comparing it with similar structures in Japanese, such as the passive structure, nominative object structure, and unaccusative verb structure, the generative mechanism of the intransitivizing *-te aru* can be confirmed. The results show that there is no null subject of any form in the intransitivizing *-te aru*. In addition, we find that the intransitivizing *-te aru* undergoes argument deletion of the original agent, differentiating it from a generally recognized transitive structure, and the nominative case can be assigned by little *v* carrying tense feature. Based on these findings, we can account for the absence of an agent and case assignment to the object in intransitivizing *-te aru* configurations.

Keywords: resultative aspect of *-te aru*; subjectless; argument structure; unaccusative verb; agent argument

1 Introduction

In traditional Japanese grammar, the resultative aspect of “*-te aru*” usually follows a transitive verb. It is syntactically divided into two types: “non-intransitivizing *-te aru*” and “intransitivizing *-te aru*” as discussed by Martin (1975), Lin (2001), Miyagawa (1989), Miyagawa & Babyonishev (2004), Sugita (2009), and Kondo (2018), as in (1a) and (1b).¹

(1) a. Non-intransitivizing

Taroo-ga doa-o ake-te aru.

Taro-NOM door-ACC open-*te aru*(result)

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¹ The following abbreviations are used: ACC = accusative, ANTICAUS = anticausative, CL = classifier, COMP = complementizer, COP=copula, DAT = dative, DECAUS = decausative, EPP = Extended Projection Principle, GEN = genitive, H = honorification, INST = instrumental, LOC = locative, NMLZ = nominalizer, NOM = nominative, OBJ = object, PERFECT = perfective, PST = past, Q = question particle, SUB = subject, TOP = Topic.

‘Taro has opened the door.’

b. Intransitivizing

Doa-**ga** ake-te aru.

door-NOM open-*te aru*(result)

‘The door has been opened.’

The intransitivizing *-te aru* has two key characteristics: (i) it does not allow for any agent argument to be present as demonstrated in (2a) and (2b), and (ii) it marks the object, typically in the accusative case, with nominative case instead.²

(2) a. *Taroo-wa/Taroo-niyotte dengen-**ga** kit-te aru.

Taro-TOP/Taro-by power-NOM cut off-*te aru*

‘Taro has cut off the power.’

b. *Dare-ka/dare-ga hana-ni mizu-**ga** yat-te aru.

who-Q/who-NOM flower-DAT water-NOM watering-*te aru*

‘Who has watered the flowers.’

Accordingly, the discussion generally focuses on the absence of the subject and the nominative realization of the object in the intransitivizing *-te aru*. While the specific structures proposed in these studies may differ, there is a prevalent consensus regarding the existence of a special covert subject within the sentence. Sugita (2009) posit the existence of a covert subject denoted as “PRO_{arb}” in certain structures, as seen in (3a), or a “special PRO” (Miyagawa & Babyonishev 2004), as in (3b).

(3) a. Hon-ga kari-te aru

book-NOM borrow-*te aru*

‘A book has been borrowed.’

[_{TP} [_{VP} PRO_{arb} [_{VP} *aru* [_{VP} PRO_i [_{VP} *hon-ga kari-te*]]]]]³

(Sugita, 2009:217)

b. [_T [_{VP} [_{IP} [_{IP} [_I [_{VP} PRO [_v [_{VP} OBJ-ga V-te]v]] I]]] *aru*] T_(no EPP)]

(Miyagawa and Babyonishev, 2004:163)

² It should be noted that the nominative object in intransitivizing *-te aru* is but a consequence of the missing subject. A similar consequence occurs in *-te aru* sentences with ditransitive verbs, where the indirect object can also be marked with the nominative case, as show in (i).

(i) Taroo-to Hanako-ga tegami-o okut-te aru (koto)

Taroo-and Hanako-NOM letter-ACC send-*te aru*

‘Letters have been sent to Taroo and Hanako.’

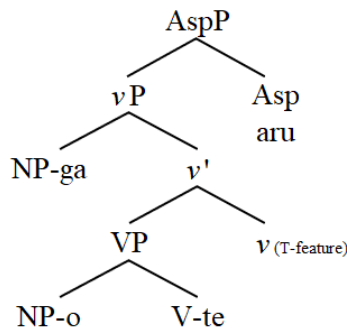
³ In this structure, *aru* should be located in the right branch, i.e., after *te*, which may be a clerical error in the original. That is: [_{TP} [_{VP} PRO_{arb} [_{VP} [_{VP} PRO_i [_{VP} *hon-ga kari-te*] *aru*]]].

The absence of explicit agent in a sentence, however, leads to the doubt about the necessity of an overt subject in the syntactic configuration and whether the intransitivizing *-te aru* has a complete argument structure like the transitive verb. For instance, Lin (2001) and Kondo (2018) argued that *-tearu* selects VP as the complement, with no external argument selected.

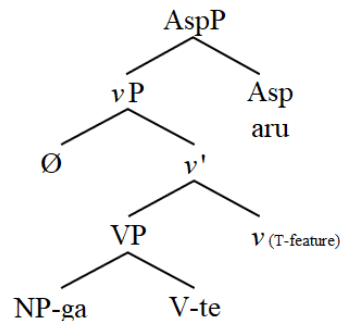
The existence of the subject also relates to the problem of the nominative case assignment on the object. If it is a complete argument structure of transitive verbs, it is natural for the object to obtain the accusative case rather than the nominative case. For the puzzle, different solutions occurred. That is, it has been suggested that the assignment of nominative case may be based on tense (Miyagawa and Babyonishev, 2004), default case (Sugita, 2009), or a special form of morphological case (Kondo, 2018).

We are herein based on more evidence to argue that there is no covert subject in the intransitivizing *-te aru*. Unlike the previous approach of treating *-te aru* as the lexical head, we demonstrate that it is more proper to analyze *-te aru* as a functional head. Thus, the configuration with non-intransitivizing *-te aru* seems not different from a structure with transitive verb, as illustrated in (4a). Conversely, the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, without covert subject, mirrors the structure of unaccusative verbs, as depicted in (4b). According to Chomsky (2021), we assume that the nominative case can be assigned by little *v* carrying tense feature. The disparities in structural composition between the non-intransitivizing *-te aru* and the intransitivizing *-te aru* primarily stem from divergences in argument structure, with the latter generated through the deletion of argument from the transitive verb structure in the lexicon.⁴

(4) a. Non-intransitivizing *-te aru*



b. Intransitivizing *-te aru*



⁴ Since “Deletion” can mean either ellipsis or deletion of a theta role in the predicate-argument structure, we adopt the latter in this paper.

This paper is organized as follows. In Section 2, we delve into the phenomenon of the “null subject” (which usually means PRO or *pro*) in the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, presenting evidence to support the absence of covert subject. The potential presence of covert subject is also discussed when *-te aru* is combined with honorific expression. In Section 3, we conduct a comparative analysis between passive sentences and nominative object sentences to scrutinize the argument structure of the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, and demonstrate that the intransitivizing *-te aru* shares syntactic similarities with unaccusative verb structure. We also elucidate the assignment of nominative case in intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration. Section 4 concludes the paper.

2 Argument structure of the intransitivizing *-te aru*

2.1 Existence of the Subject in the Intransitivizing *-te aru* and the challenges

Previous literature primarily discusses the structure of *-te aru* sentences as follows. Firstly, there may be an agent subject in a sentence, as both types of *-te aru* sentences can be semantically interpreted as someone consciously completing an action (Sugita, 2009). A part of intransitivizing *-te aru* sentences can be examined through subject and object honorifications. As illustrated in (5a), the presence of subject honorification suggests the existence of a respectable individual in the sentence, acting as a subject, which cannot be the *hon* ‘book’ itself.⁵ In the object-honorific expression, as shown in (5b), it is assumed that the agent subject is the speaker, and the speaker conveys respect for the object *sensee* ‘teacher’. Consequently, Sugita (2009) further posited that all intransitivizing *-te aru* sentences should feature an arbitrary subject (PRO_{arb}) at the syntactic level, which functions as a control structure, as shown in (6a). Similarly, Miyagawa and Babyonyshev (2004) incorporated a “special PRO” into their proposed structure, as demonstrated in (6b).

- (5) a. Hon-ga o-kaki-ni-nat-te aru.
 book-NOM write-SUB.H-*te aru*
 ‘A book has been written.’
 b. Sensee-ga o-maneki-moosi-age-te aru.
 teacher-NOM invite-OBJ.H-*te aru*
 ‘The teacher has been invited.’

⁵ The grammaticality of (5a) is doubtful, as it is not considered grammatical by some native speakers.

(Sugita, 2009:219/220)

(6) a. Hon-ga kari-te aru.

book-NOM borrow-te aru

‘A book has been borrowed.’

[_{TP} [_{VP} PRO_{arb}_i [_{VP} aru [_{VP} PRO_i [_{VP} hon-ga kari-te]]]]]

(Sugita, 2009:217)

b. [_T [_{VP} [_{IP} [_{IP} [_I [_{VP} PRO [_v [_{VP} OBJ-ga V-te]v]] I]]] aru] T_(no EPP)]

(Miyagawa and Babyonishev, 2004:163)

However, the proposals by Sugita (2009) and Miyagawa and Babyonishev (2004) raise certain challenges when it comes to uniformly incorporating covert agent arguments into all intransitivizing *-te aru* structures. To begin with, Kondo (2018) observes that with the object marked nominative case as well, the *-te aru* in (7a) indicating perfect can be used with subject honorification, while the one in (7b) indicating the resultant state cannot be used.

(7) a. *pro*# Kaityou-ga yon-de-o-arininaru.

chairman-NOM call-te aru-SUB.H

‘The chairman has been called.’

b. *Sensei-ga taosi-te-o-ari-ninaru.

teacher-NOM defeat-te aru-SUB.H

‘The teacher has been defeated’

(Kondo, 2018:75)

Second, not all *-te aru* sentences indicate conscious actions by an individual. It may also portray actions in an unconscious state that merely signify the occurrence of an event (Sugimura, 2002), as in (8a) and (8b). It appears that not all intransitivizing *-te aru* structures necessitate a covert subject.

(8) a. Oya, konna tokoro-ni tamago-ga un-de aru.

Oh this place-LOC egg-NOM lay-te aru

‘Ah, there’s eggs being laid in this place.’

b. Oya, gasu-ga tukeppanasi-ni si-te aru.

Oh gas-NOM leave on-DAT do-te aru

‘Oh, the gas has been left on.’

(Sugimura, 2002:161)

Furthermore, if there is an arbitrary subject (PRO_{arb}), it should be replaceable with a

specific subject, as shown in (9a) and (9b). Yet, this replacement cannot be applied to intransitivizing *-te aru* sentences, as no overt subject of any form can appear in the sentence.

- (9) a. PRO_{arb} yoku undoosuru koto-wa ii koto-da.
regularly exercise thing-TOP good thing-COP
‘It’s good to exercise regularly.’
b. Kimi-ga(PRO_{arb}) yoku undoo-suru koto-wa ii koto-da.
you-NOM regularly exercise thing-TOP good thing-COP
‘It’s good for you to exercise regularly.’

Apart from the above two proposals, Kondo (2018) also tried to address the issue. Expanding on Masuoka’s (1987) classification of semantic functions, Kondo (2018) argued that “type A” (corresponding to the intransitivizing *-te aru*), exemplified in (10), possesses a special syntactic structure without covert subject. Under this view, two essential conditions must be satisfied. First, the intra-argument must be marked by the nominative case, and second, the predicate verb should be a “change verb” (a verb that signifies a change in arrangement, record, or state). And as in (7b), type A is ungrammatical with the subject honorification.

- (10) Mado-ga ake-te aru.
window-NOM open-*te aru*
‘The window has been opened.’
[TP [V_{asp}P [V_{asp}’ [VP [V’ (NP-ni) [V’ [VP mado ake-te] -ar]]] V_{asp}(no EPP)]T-ru]
- (Kondo, 2018:115)

In contrast, sentences like (11a) and (11b) fall under the “type B” (corresponding to the non-intransitivizing *-te aru*). In (11a), the verb does not belong to the category of “change verbs.” And (11b) successfully withstands the subject honorification test, where the nominative noun *kaityou* ‘chairman’ is clearly not the object of respect in the subject honorification context. Thus, the situation makes syntacticians speculate that a “special” covert subject (*pro*#) must exist within the sentence, and the syntactic structure can also be analyzed in the same way as that of the non-intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration. That being said, the sentence structures in (11a) and (11b), which have the syntactic characteristics of the intransitivizing *-te aru*, should be treated as the same non-intransitivizing *-te aru* as (11c).

- (11) a. Senmonka-ga yadot-te aru
Expert-NOM hire-*te aru*

‘Experts have been hired.’

- b. *pro*# kaityou-ga yon-de-o-ari-ninaru.
 chairman-NOM call-*te aru*-SUB.H

‘The chairman has been called.’

- c. Taroo-ga ticketto-o tot-te aru.
 Taro-NOM ticket-ACC get-*te aru*

‘Taro has gotten the tickets.’

[TP [_{Vasp}P [_{Vasp}’ [VP [V’ [_vP NP/*pro*# [v’ [VP chikett-o tot-te] v_(EPP)]]-ar]] Vasp_(no EPP)]]
 T-ru]

(Kondo, 2018:10/75/115)

Even so, as shown above, Kondo’s (2018) proposal seemingly leans more towards semantics than syntax. While it can explain the subtle differences in semantic expression between the two, it obscures the significant differences between non-intransitivizing and intransitivizing *-te aru* at the syntactic level.

For instance, it cannot fully explain why the “type A” in (10) and the “type B” in (11a) and (11b) have the same case marking despite having different argument structures. Kondo (2018) posits that (11a) and (11b) possess the complete argument structure characterized by transitive verbs, aligning them with the non-intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration as in (11c). If so, the issue immediately arises in how the object obtains nominative case. According to the abstract case theory, if it is a transitive verb in (11a) and (11b), the object should obtain accusative case rather than nominative case.

Furthermore, the *-te aru* structure with honorific form in (11b) may not be a general intransitivizing *-te aru* sentence. As Kishimoto (2012) states, honorific verbs may have their own projections. And there is *-te aru* sentence as in (12) that allow the object to be marked by nominative case even when the semantic subject is present. (11b) and (12) are likely to have similar syntactic structure. However, we only discuss two simple types as shown in (1a) and (1b).⁶

- (12) Taroo-ga sono hon-ga kat-te aru (koto)
 Taro-NOM that book-NOM buy-*te aru*

⁶ There is another type of *-te aru* sentence in which the nominative phrase seem to be derived from embedded clause.

(i) kono honi-ga [kodomo-tati-ni ti yomu yooni] it-te aru.
 this book-NOM children-to read COMP say-*te aru*
 ‘This book is such that I already told the children to read it.’

‘Taroo has bought the book.’

In summary, the covert subject posited in the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration may not be indispensable and could be considered a redundant element that is not inherently generated within the sentence. This will be further explored and verified in the subsequent section.

2.2 The Intended Meaning and Argument Realization within Intransitivizing *-te aru*

As explained above, the view that *-te aru* configurations convey the meaning of “someone intentionally did it” implies the presence of a covert subject in the sentence. It is noteworthy that many intransitive verbs in Japanese are derived from transitive verbs. Those intransitive sentences can be understood as expressing a sense of intentional or manmade action. Unlike sentences with transitive verbs, those intransitive configurations do not necessitate a covert subject in the position of [Spec, vP] or elsewhere, as exemplified in (13a) and (13b) below. That is, even if the actions inherently denote a sense of requiring human intervention, viz., *kuruma* ‘the car’ cannot park itself at the station and *sakura* ‘the cherry tree’ will not plant itself in the yard, the nominative case markers after *kuruma* ‘the car’ and *sakura* ‘the cherry tree’ excludes the possibilities to assume syntactic positions for covert subjects in (12a) and (12b).

- (13) a. *Kuruma-ga ekimae-ni tomat-ta*
car-NOM station.front-LOC stop-PST
‘The car stopped in front of the station.’
b. *Niwa-ni sakura-no ki-ga uwat-teiru*
yard-LOC cheery-GEN tree-NOM plant-PERFECT
‘There are cherry trees planted in the yard.’

Moreover, *-te aru* can co-occur with passive expressions, such as in (14a), which alleviates the problem of the agent argument being impossible to present, as it could usually be introduced by preposition *-niyotte* ‘by’. In passive clauses, since the verb itself does not select external arguments, if the agent argument is not introduced by a preposition, it will be absent from the sentence. Despite the lack of an agent argument, the sentence can still convey a sense of intentional action. If there is a contention that a covert agent is implied in the sentence, it would need to be situated at a higher position than the passive projection and linked to the agent introduced by preposition for interpretive clarity. As in (14b), the

passive projection does not introduce an agent, the covert argument (PRO or any other similar elements with relevant property) will not be applicable.

- (14) a. [(Taroo-niyotte) [_{VP} mado-ga ake]-rare]-te aru.
 Taro-by window-NOM open-PASS-*te aru*
 ‘The window has been opened (by Taroo)’
 b.* PRO_i [Ø_i [_{VP} mado-ga ake]-rare]-te aru.
 window-NOM open-PASS-*te aru*
 ‘The window has been opened’

Notably, *-te aru* does not inherently carry arguments. When *-te aru* is combined with an idiomatic phrase, the original meaning of the idiom can be maintained (Miyagawa and Babyonishev, 2004; Sugita, 2009), as in (15). The observation leads Sugita (2009:190) to conclude that raising structures are the ones that retain the specific idiomatic meanings, while controlling structures tend to reduce idioms to their literal interpretations. The reason why Sugita makes such a conclusion might be that control structures involve two arguments, with the higher one controlling the lower one through c-command, whereas raising structures have only one argument that occupies two positions through movement. Consequently, the intransitivizing *-te aru* cannot be classified as a control structure, but a raising structure. Thus, the single argument in the structure must be a nominative object.⁷

- (15) a. Te-o kiru
 hand-ACC cut
 Lit: ‘to cut a hand.’
 Idiomatic meaning: ‘to end a relationship’
 b. Yakuza-to te-ga kit-te aru
 yakuza-with hand-NOM cut-*te aru*
 ‘The relationship with the yakuza has been ended.’

(Sugita, 2009:197)

As such, it is evident that the *-te aru* configuration does not inherently necessitate the presence of an agent argument. If this idea is on the right track, we could posit that the interpretation of “someone intentionally did it” in *-te aru* sentences seems to be derived from the semantic properties of *-te aru* itself rather than argument.

⁷ To construct appropriate syntactic structures, Sugita (2009) still regards the *-te aru* sentence structure as a control structure.

2.3 Subject Detection of the Intransitivizing *-te aru*

To further investigate whether there exists the agent argument, we can employ some methods to verify the idea. Firstly, we will make use of the interference effect of the subject-oriented adverb *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ to detect the (non-)existence of a covert subject. The subject-oriented nature of the adverb *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ is constrained to the clause in which it is situated and cannot extend beyond clauses to directly refer to the subject of the matrix clause, as illustrated in (16a). In cases where the subject is elided from the clause, *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ points to the covert subject *pro*, which functions as a bridge in the clause and establishes the co-reference with the subject of the matrix clause, as in (16b). Thus, the covert subject *pro* co-refers with the subject *Taroo*.

- (16) a. Taroo_j-wa [imooto_i-ga mizukara_{i/*j} kodomo-**o** kyooiku-si-ta] to it-ta.
 Taro-TOP sister-NOM by oneself kid-ACC discipline-PST C say-PST
 ‘Taro said that his sister has disciplined the child by herself.’
- b. Taroo_i-wa [*pro*_i mizukara_i kodomo-**o** kyooiku-si-te aru] to it-ta.
 Taro-TOP by oneself kid-ACC discipline-*te aru* C say-PST
 ‘Taro says he has disciplined the child by himself.’

Based on this effect, if a covert subject is inherent in the intransitivizing *-te aru* structure, it must be the same as non-intransitivizing *-te aru* as in (16b). The outcome is illustrated in (17a), a suitable referent for *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ cannot be identified within the clause to establish a connection with the subject of the matrix clause. The subject-oriented nature of *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ remains unfulfilled, leading to an ambiguous interpretation of the sentence. In (17a), *mizukara* cannot even refer to an arbitrary individual and is constrained to point to the subject object *kodomo* ‘child’ within the clause, consequently yielding an unclear interpretation. Upon removing *mizukara* ‘by oneself’, as in (17b), the sentence regains its coherence and can be correctly interpreted.

- (17) a. *Taroo_i-wa [*pro*_i mizukara_i kodomo-**ga** kyooiku-si-*te aru*] to it-ta.
 Taro-TOP by oneself kid-ACC discipline-*te aru* C say-PST
 ‘Taro said that the child has been disciplined by himself.’
- b. Taroo-wa [kodomo-**ga** kyooiku-si-*te aru*] to it-ta.
 Taro-TOP kid-ACC discipline-*te aru* C say-PST
 ‘Taro said that the child has been disciplined.’

In addition, the adverb *wazato* ‘deliberately’ can also be used to detect the presence

of agent argument in a sentence. It is sensitive to the agent argument, as in (18a) and (18b). Specifically, the verb in (18a) is a transitive verb and the sentence contains a silent agent, while the verb in (18b) is an intransitive verb and there is no agent in the sentence.

- (18) a. Wazato kirokuyooshi-o yabut-ta.
 deliberately record paper-ACC tear up-PST
 ‘(Some one) deliberately tore up the record paper.’
 b. *Wazato kirokuyooshi-ga yaburet-ta.
 deliberately record paper-NOM tear up-PST
 ‘The recording paper was deliberately torn.’

Unlike the non-intransitivizing *-te aru*, intransitivizing *-te aru* does not permit *wazato* ‘deliberately,’ as shown in (19a) and (19b).

- (19) a. Wazato kirokuyooshi-o yabut-te aru.
 deliberately record paper-ACC tear up-*te aru*
 ‘The recording paper has been deliberately torn.’
 b. *Wazato kirokuyooshi-ga yabut-te aru.
 deliberately record paper-NOM tear up-*te aru*
 ‘The recording paper has been torn deliberately.’

Cleft clause also can serve as a valuable tool for isolating specific elements within a sentence for such an examination, as in (20a) and (20b). In (20b), the semantic implication of the cleft sentence suggests that *Tanaka* assumes the role of the agent. Conversely, when applies to intransitivizing *-te aru*, it becomes apparent that there is a lack of an argument within the cleft clause that could refer to *Tanaka* in matrix clause, as illustrated in (21a) and (21b).

- (20) a. Tanaka-ga mado-o ake-te aru.
 Tanaka-NOM window-ACC open-*te aru*
 ‘Tanaka has opened the window’
 b. [_i made-o ake-te aru] no-wa Tanaka_i-da
 window-ACC open-*te aru* NMLZ-TOP Tanaka-COP
 ‘It is Tanaka who has opened the window’
 (21) a. Mado-ga ake-te aru.
 window-NOM open-*te aru*
 ‘The window has been opened’
 b. *[_i mado-ga ake-tearu] no-wa Tanaka_i-da.

window-ACC open-*te aru* NMLZ-TOP Tanaka/-COP

‘It is Tanaka who has opened the window’

Since the subject cannot be discerned, and we are unable to obtain any interpretation of the agent argument from the tests of relative clauses and cleft clauses, indicating that the theta role of agent cannot be produced in the intransitivizing *-te aru*. For this reason, we might assume that there could have been a change in the argument structure in intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, and the agent argument might not enter the syntactic derivation of the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration.

2.4 Intransitive verbalization in Japanese

As there might be no overt subject presenting in the intransitivizing *-te aru* sentence and a clear semantic absence of an agent subject, the “null subject” problem in intransitivizing *-te aru* is not a general argument ellipsis. Accordingly, it can be tentatively assumed that agent argument does not occur within the corresponding structure. In Japanese, the deletion of argument is observable. For example, many intransitive verbs are derived by deleting the agent argument of transitive verbs (Jacobsen, 1992; Kageyama, 1996, 2016). Kageyama (1996, 2016) investigated the semantic structure of verbal adjuncts such as *katteni* ‘all by itself’, *te-o tukusite* ‘with great effort’ and assumed two types of lexemes for the intransitive verbalization: anticausative verb, whose agents are erased completely, as in (22a), and decausative verb, whose agents are preserved in lexical semantic structure despite being syntactically invisible, as in (22b).

(22) a. Anticausatives

Kami-ga {katteni / *te-o tukusite yatto} yabur-e-ta.
 paper-NOM {all by itself / *with great effort} tear-ANTICAUS-PST
 ‘The paper tore {by itself / *with great effort}.’

b. Decausatives

Takaramono-ga {te-o tukusite yatto / *katteni} mituk-at-ta.
 treasure-NOM {with great effort / *all by itself} find-DECAUS-PST
 ‘The treasure was found {with great effort / *all by itself}.’

(Kageyama, 2016:91)

This derivation is also observed in two types of lexical V-V compound verb, exemplified by the thematic compound verbs *uti-agaru* ‘shot up’ in (23a) and the aspectual

compound verbs *ami-agaru* ‘knitted’ in (23b).

- (23) a. Atarasii sooti-de roketto/hanabi-ga uti-agat-ta.
 new device-INST rocket/fireworks-NOM hit-go up-PST
 ‘A rocket/Fireworks shot up by means of a new device.’
 b. Seetaa-ga kuroo-site/*katteni ami-agat-ta.
 Sweater-NOM with great effort/*by itself knit-go up-PST
 ‘The sweater was knit with great effort/*by itself.’

(Kageyama, 2016:101/109)

The agent of decausative verbs is not visible in syntax, but the residual human factor in the lexical semantic structure aligns with the situation of intransitivizing *-te aru*. Therefore, we may first conduct decausative detection on intransitivizing *-te aru*. As in (24), there are no obvious traces of the presence of agent in the lexical semantic structure.

- (24). ??Mado-ga te-o tukusite yatto ake-*te aru*.
 window-NOM with great effort open-*te aru*
 ‘The window was opened with a great effort.’

Interestingly, this sentence also fails to pass the anticausative detection, as in (25), since the nominative phrase in the sentence cannot autonomously perform the action of the predicate. The results of (24) and (25) suggest that *ake* ‘open’ presupposes an agent but does not necessarily imply that agent is present in the lexical semantic structure.

- (25). *Mado-ga katteni ake-*te aru*
 window-NOM by itself open-*te aru*
 ‘The window opened by itself.’

In addition, unlike intransitivizing *-te aru* sentence, the anticausative verb structure can successfully pass subject detection, as in (26a), and the agent of the decausative verb structure can appear directly in a certain form, as in (26b).

- (26) a. Kami-wa zibun-de katteni yabu-re-ta
 paper-TOP self-INST by itself tear-ANTICAUS-PST
 ‘The paper broke by itself.’
 b. Takaramono-ga kaizoku-ni mituk-at-ta.
 treasure-NOM pirate-by find-DECAUS-PST
 ‘The treasure was found by pirates.’

In short, in the intransitivizing *-te aru*, not only is the agent argument syntactically absent, but semantically, the theta role of the argument is not preserved. This is consistent

with our detection in section 2.3. Although the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration differs from the anticausative verb structure in the properties of the nominative phrase, it is consistent in the deletion of the agent argument.⁸

2.5 Interim Summary

Through the examination of non-volitional *-te aru* sentences (8a) and (8b), passive sentences (14), and idioms (15), it becomes evident that *-te aru* on its own does not introduce arguments, and there is no obligatory requirement for agent arguments to be present in the sentence. Furthermore, looking at intransitive verb sentences (which convey a sense of intentional action) as in (13), the semantic meaning of “intentionally did it” expressed by *-te aru* does not necessarily imply the presence of agent arguments, as the semantic features are not inherently linked to argument structure. The use of adverbs such as *mizukara* ‘by oneself’ further supports the absence of agent arguments in intransitivizing *-te aru* configurations.

As discussed in 2.4, Japanese features a mechanism for deriving intransitive verbs from transitive verbs. The derivation can be found in the formation of thematic and aspectual compound (Jacobsen, 1992; Kageyama, 1996, 2016). As an aspectual suffix, intransitivizing *-te aru* also requires to delete the agent argument, when attach to a transitive verb. Since the No Tampering Condition (NTC) requires that no information entering the syntactic operation can be added or subtracted arbitrarily (Chomsky 2008), the deletion of argument must necessarily occur at the lexical level before entering the syntactic computations.⁹

Semantically, the agent θ -role is part of the lexical semantic structure of the transitive verb, and this is recorded in the lexicon. Syntactically, however, the external argument is introduced by *v* or Voice (see Pytkänen, 2008; Harley, 2013; Legate, 2014), as best

⁸ From a comparative observation of Chinese, Japanese and English, Lin (2001) found that Chinese is also not strict in its selection of external argument. For some specific intransitive verbs, the agent argument is not necessary. The following examples are agentless in Chinese (see Lin, 2001; Huang, 2009).

(i) a. zhe-sou motuoting yijing kai-le xuduo nian le.
 this-CL motorboat already drive-le many year PST
 ‘This motorboat has already been driven for many years.’
 b. zhe-tiao he bu neng kai motuoting.
 this-CL river not can drive motorboat
 ‘A motorboat can’t be driven on this river.’

(Huang 2009: 54)

⁹ According to the Strong Minimalist Thesis, language computations follow the basic steps of “lexicon → syntactic generation → semantic/phonological-phonetic computations,” and “semantic/phonetic representations” interact with external contexts to ultimately form appropriate expressions (see Mao, 2020).

exemplified by passive sentences. Since we do not detect the agent in the semantic structure either, we suggest that the verb in intransitivizing *-te aru* sentence loses the agent role in the lexical semantic structure. When generating intransitivizing *-te aru* sentences, the derivation that selects the external argument to enter the syntactic operation will crash as it fails to satisfy the semantic interpretation in the C-I system.

Thus, the process takes place at the lexicon, and involves deleting the agent role, and the suffix *-te aru* which triggered the deletion is also used to mark the shift of argument structure, rather than undergoing morphological changes in the verb. It should be noted that this shifting is not obligatory, since both intransitivizing *-te aru* and non-intransitivizing *-te aru* are possible. The structures of passive sentences and nominative object structures share similarities in their ability to reduce arguments by combining verbs with specific affixes. In the subsequent section, a detailed comparative analysis on this aspect will be provided.

3 Syntactic structure of the Intransitivizing *-te aru*

The task at this moment is to explore the core syntactic characteristics of the intransitive *-te aru*. As previously noted, there is no overt subject that can be directly observed in intransitivizing *-te aru* configurations, no matter they are general intransitive forms or structures involving honorification. Along this line, we will discuss the syntactic property of intransitivizing *-te aru*, and then conduct a comparative analysis between intransitivizing *-te aru* and passive configurations and nominative object structures in Japanese to check the argument status of intransitivizing *-te aru*.

3.1 Against the VP analysis of intransitivizing *-te aru*

Given that the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration lacks external argument, Lin (2001) and Kondo (2018) provide a VP analysis for the phenomenon. Kondo (2018) assuming that the intransitivizing *-te aru* is a *vP* projection, and the verb *aru* directly selects VP as its complement rather than *vP*, the external argument can be precluded, as shown in (27).

(27) $[_{TP}[_{vP}[_{V'}[_{VP}NP\ V]\ V\text{-aru}]\ v]T]$ Kondo(2018: 113)

However, the solution to elide *v*-projection may not be appropriate. Such a proposal would compromise the universality of the functional spine assumed for syntactic structure (for the commonly adopted functional phase heads see Chomsky 2008; a.o.). If the

functional head *v* is elided, the immediate consequence would be the synchronous elimination of the causative meaning, which is typically denoted by *v*.

Another important consideration for preserving *v*-projection is that the structure must reserve a position for light verb. In Japanese, when the verb is followed by a particle such as *sae* ‘even’, the verb *su(ru)* ‘do’ needs to be inserted to form a do-support-like effect, As illustrated in (28a) and (28b).

- (28) a. Taro-ga kono hon-o yoma-nakat-ta.
 Taro-NOM this book-ACC read-NEG-PST
 ‘Taro didn’t read this book.’
 b. Taro-ga kono hon-o yomi-sae-shi-nakat-ta.
 Taro-NOM this book-ACC read-even-do-NEG-PST
 ‘Taro didn’t even read this book.’

The position of *su(ru)* in (28b) is lower than the negative projection and higher than the lexical verb projection. Therefore, it is not a dummy verb, but a light verb, locating at *v* (Sakai et al. 2004; Ivana and Sakai 2009). The intransitivizing *-te aru* can likewise form the same morphological structure, as in (29b).

- (29) a. Setubi-ga totonoe-te are-ba, daijyoo bu.
 equipment prepare-*te aru*-if fine
 ‘If the equipment is prepared, it will be fine.’
 b. Setubi-ga totonoe-sae-shi-te are-ba, daijyoo bu.
 equipment prepare-even-do-*te aru*-if fine
 ‘If the equipment is prepared, it will be fine.’

According to Sakai et al. (2004), *su(ru)* ‘do’ can participate in transitivity alternation of adjectives as in (30). Without having the properties of a heavy verb, it is also a light verb located in *v*. The light verb can likewise occur in intransitivizing *-te aru*, as in (31).

- (30) Taro-wa heya-o atatakaku-shi-tei-nakat-ta.
 Taro-TOP room-ACC warm-do-PERFECT-NEG-PST
 ‘Taro did not keep the room warm.’
 (31) Heya-ga atatakaku-shi-te aru.
 Room-NOM warm-do-*te aru*
 ‘The room is kept warm.’

Furthermore, there is evidence that *-te aru* is not a lexical head formed by the verb *aru*, but a functional head. It is widely discussed in literature that aspectual words belong

to functional categories (see Travis 1991; Borer 1998; a.o.). In Japanese, Fukuda (2012) argues that aspectual verbs, such as *-owaru* ‘end’ and *-hajimeru* ‘start’, can be regarded as the functional heads. Following Fukuda’s (2012) diagnostic methods (mainly derived from Cinque 2003, 2004; Wurmbrand 2004), we can find some evidence to certify *-te aru* as a functional head.

First, while lexical heads can select a diverse range of complement forms, functional heads obligatorily select a certain complement form (Wurmbrand 2004: 1004). As Fukuda (2012: 1010) demonstrated, certain functional heads in Japanese cannot select CP as its complement. *-Te aru* also exhibits this requirement. As in (32a), *-Te aru* only takes vP as its complement. It is impossible to take a CP as its complement, as shown in (32b), respectively.

- (32) a. Tanaka-wa yoyaku-o tot-te aru.
 Tanaka-TOP appointment-ACC get-*te aru*.
 ‘Tanaka has made an appointment.’
- b.* Tanaka-wa yoyaku-o toru to -te aru.
 Tanaka-TOP appointment-ACC get COMP -*te aru*.
 ‘Tanaka has made an appointment.’

Second, not only is it morphologically necessary to select vP, but *-te aru* is also highly grammaticalized, losing the same ability as the lexical verb *aru* ‘have’ to select an argument.¹⁰ This is also discussed in section 2.2.

- (33) a. Tanaka-wa yoyaku-o tot-ta koto-ga aru.
 Tanaka-TOP appointment-ACC get-PST NMLZ-NOM *aru*.
 ‘Tanaka has made an appointment before’
- b. * Tanaka-wa yoyaku-o tot-ta koto-ga te aru.
 Tanaka-TOP appointment-ACC get-PST NMLZ-NOM *te aru*.
 ‘Tanaka has made an appointment’

In this case, observing whether the word has undergone a transition from lexical form to functional form from a diachronic perspective is also one of the distinguishing methods. The process of grammaticalization typically involves changes in semantic, morphological, and syntactic characteristics (Fukuda 2012:1013). Along this line, it seems that we can speculate that the aspectual function of *-te aru* might be derived from the verb *aru*

¹⁰ It does not mean that all functional heads are incapable of carrying argument.

‘exist/have’ that is an intransitive verb representing existence and possession, as in (34). After selecting a *vP* complement, the original meaning of *aru* ‘exist/have’ changes to express a result or state.

- (34) a. Heya-ni isu-ga aru.
 room-LOC chair-Nom exist
 ‘There are chairs in the room.’
 b. Kanozyo-ni-wa futari-no kodomo-ga aru.
 she-DET-TOP two-Gen child-NOM have
 ‘She has two children.’

Third, unlike lexical heads, functional heads present strict word order requirements for each other (Fukuda 2012: 1010). In Japanese, there are six aspectual heads similar to *-te aru*: *-te iru* ‘doing’, *-te iku* ‘going’, *-te kuru* ‘coming’, *-te simau* ‘ending up’, *-te miru* ‘trying’, and *-te oku* ‘putting’. According to Kondo’s (2018) observation, these words follow a certain hierarchical structure with each other, as in (35) and (36), and the position where *-te aru* appears is on the far right.

- (35) a. Kaigi-no shiryoo-wa moo zyunbi-si-te oi-te aru.
 Meeting-Gen document-TOP already prepare-do-te *oku-te aru*.
 ‘The meeting documents are prepared.’
 b.* Kaigi-no shiryoo-wa moo zyunbi-shi -te at-te oi-ta.
 Meeting-Gen document-TOP already prepare-do-te *aru-te oku*-PST.
 (36) a. Syukudai-o yat-te sima-te aru.
 homework-ACC do-te *sima-te aru*.
 ‘The homework is done already.’
 b.* Syukudai-o yat-te at-te simau.
 homework-ACC do-te *aru-te simau*.
 ‘The homework is done already.’

Kondo(2018: 178)

Based on the above observations, we conclude that *-te aru* is functional head, and then *vP* is selected as its complement. The structure of non-intransitivizing *-te aru* is exhibited below, and the intransitivizing *-te aru* will be further analyzed in the next section.

- (37) [_{InflP} [_{Infl}’ [_{AspP} [_{Asp}’ [_{vP} NP-ga [_v’ [_{vP} NP-**o** V-te] *v*]]-aru]] INFL]].

3.2 Comparing Passive Structure and Nominative Object Structure with intransitivizing *-te aru*

Previous studies have discussed the similarity between the intransitivizing *-te aru* and passive verb forms, such as Masuoka (1987), Miyagawa (1989), and Sugita (2009). Drawing on the similarities with passive structure, Soejima (2007) and Suda (2010) have argued that the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration constitutes a single argument structure. In general, passive sentences are generally divided into two types: direct, as in (38a), and indirect, as in (38b).

- (38) a. Taro_o-wa inu-ni kam-are-ta.
Taro-TOP dog-DAT bite-PASS-PST
'Taro was bitten by a dog.'
- b. Taro_o-wa titi-ni sin-are-ta.
Taro-TOP father-DAT die-PASS-PST
'Taro has lost his father.'

Taking into consideration the relevant research, such as (38a)(38b), we can readily observe that the similarities between the intransitivizing *-te aru* and direct passive structures can primarily be identified in the following four aspects: (i) the semantic object *Taroo* marked by the nominative case, (ii) Specific suffixes were added (*-te aru*, *-rare*), (iii) the semantic object serving as the main perspective of the sentence, and (iv) the elimination of the necessity for the semantic subject.

Nonetheless, we cannot analyze the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration as a passive structure, for some syntactic distinctions still exist between intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration and passive structure. In a passive sentence, a semantic object with nominative case is a grammatical subject, whereas the nominative phrase in intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration retains object-like properties and does not qualify as a subject. This distinction is evident in the context of anaphor (see Muraki, 1986; Miyagawa and Babyonishev, 2004; Sugita, 2009; Kondo, 2018, among others). Considering the subject-oriented anaphor *zibun* 'oneself' in (39), *Taroo* cannot serve as the antecedent for the anaphor.

- (39) *Taro_o-ga zibun_i-no naihu-de koroshi-*te aru*.

Taro-NOM self-GEN knife-INST kill-*te aru*
‘Taro killed with his own dagger.’

(Kondo, 2018:71)

The subject honorification, as in (40a), requires a subject to be respected, and it cannot be the patient *hon* ‘book’ in the sentence. In (40b), the object honorification take the object *sensei* ‘teacher’ as the person to be respected.

- (40) a. Hon-ga o-kaki-ni-nat-te aru
book-NOM write-SUB.HONORIFIC-*te aru*
‘A book has been written.’
b. Sensee-ga o-maneki-moosi-age-te aru.
teacher-NOM invite-OBJ.HONORIFIC-*te aru*
‘The teacher has been invited.’

(Sugita, 2009:219/220)

Therefore, both the subject oriented adverb test and the honorific test indicate that the nominative phrase in intransitivizing *-te aru* is not a subject in the sentence. If the subject locates at [Spec, INFL], the object in the intransitivizing *-te aru* does not move to the subject position (for the same idea see Miyagawa & Babyonishev 2004: 168).

Another distinction between passive sentences and intransitivizing *-te aru* configurations is that passive sentences have the capability to introduce agent arguments through prepositions, whereas intransitivizing *-te aru* sentences do not permit any form of agent. As a result, from these two distinctions, it can be seen that in intransitivizing *-te aru* neither introduces external arguments nor any elements that rise to [Spec, INFL].

The characteristic of the nominative phrase in the intransitivizing *-te aru* also bears resemblance to the nominative object structure. The typical nominative object structure, as seen in (41), involves a stative predicate derived from transitive verb, which accompanied by the stative suffix *-(rar)e* ‘can’. This structure also features a limited number of intransitive verbs derived from transitive verbs, exemplified in (42a) and (42b). Through the use of anaphora, subject honorification, object honorification, and other tests, it becomes apparent that the nominative object just functions as object rather than subject (see Tada, 1992; Takano, 2003; Kishimoto, 2005; Saito, 2012; Kasai, 2018, etc.).¹¹

¹¹ Saito (1982) suggests that the object *ga* is some kind of focus marker, and that the nominative object fulfills an interpretive requirement by playing a subject-like role. In this sense, the nominative object in intransitivizing *-te aru* sentence has the same properties.

(41) Tanaka-wa nihongo-[ga/o] hanas-eru.

Tanaka-TOP Japanese-NOM/ACC speak-can

‘Tanaka can speak Japanese.’

(42) a. Sora-ni hosi-ga mieru.

Sky-LOC star-NOM can see/be seen

‘The stars can be seen in the sky.’

b. Watasi-wa hosi-o mi-ta.

I-TOP star-ACC see-PST

‘I saw the stars’

As shown in (41), the nominative-accusative alternation is permissible for the object. This looks similar to the pair of non-intransitivizing *-te aru* and intransitivizing *-te aru*. However, the idea of analyzing these two pairs in the same way is not feasible. Unlike intransitivizing *-te aru*, (41) is difficult to be treated as a simple predicate clause, and its argument structure is also relatively complete.¹² Instead, the pair in (42) is almost identical to the pair of non-intransitivizing *-te aru* and intransitivizing *-te aru*. In our analysis, intransitivizing *-te aru* is limited to simple clause, closer to examples as in (42a), in which the subject is optional and there may be no subject at all in many instances. Regarding the form in (42a), since intransitive verbs lack the capacity to assign accusative cases, the object can only receive the nominative case.

In this case, the mechanism of nominative object structure by which the object acquires the nominative case and the characteristics of subjectless can offer insights for a deeper understanding of *-te aru* sentences. This suggests the possibility of having only a semantic object and assigning it the nominative case without raising it to a subject position in a structure as intransitivizing *-te aru*. Given the high degree of similarity between intransitivizing *-te aru* and nominative object structure of simple predicate, we are inclined

¹² Currently, there is no unified analysis for nominative-accusative alternation (see Tada, 1992; Takano, 2003; Kishimoto, 2005; Saito, 2012; Kasai, 2018, etc.). More examples of nominative object constructions are added below:

(i) Kono kōgi-ga wakari-yasui (koto)

this lecture-NOM understand-easy

‘This lecture is easy to understand.’

(ii) Kono kinoko-ga tabe-rare

ru (koto)

this mushroom-NOM eat-can

‘This mushroom is edible.’

In addition, (iii) (i.e., 12) is highly similar on the surface with nominative object sentence in (41). They are also likely to have similar syntactic structure. This will be the subject of our future research.

(iii) Taroo-ga sono hon-ga kat-te aru (koto)

Taroo-NOM that book-NOM buy-*te aru*

‘Taroo has bought the book.’

to assume that they have the same syntactic structure.

3.3 The Analysis of Intransitivizing *-te aru* as Unaccusative Verb Structure

As mentioned in the previous section, nominative object structure and intransitivizing *-te aru* have the same properties, and we will analyze them from the perspective of simple verb predicate. In terms of verb types, the verbs in the nominative object structure as in (42a) are unaccusative verbs. According to Perlmutter's (1978) Unaccusative Hypothesis, intransitive verbs are distinguished as unergative and unaccusative verbs in parallel with transitive verbs, as shown in (43a), (43b), and (43c).

(43) a. Transitive

Tanaka-ga hon-o yon-da.
 Tanaka-NOM book-ACC read-PST
 'Tanaka read book.'

b. Unergative

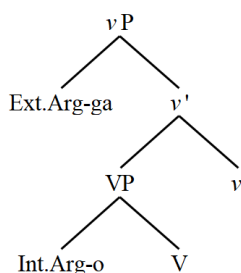
Kodomo-ga hasit-ta.
 child-NOM run-PST
 'The child ran.'

c. Unaccusative

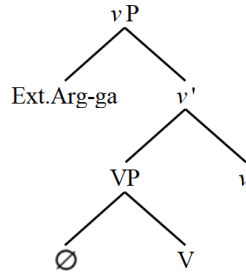
Kabin-ga ware-da.
 vase-NOM break-PST
 'The vase broken.'

By the assumption of *v*P phase (see Chomsky 2008, among others), the sole argument of unergative verbs is the external argument, which is generated at [Spec, *v*P] and corresponds to the position of the outer argument for transitive verbs, as in (44a) and (44b). For unaccusative verbs, the sole argument is the internal argument situated at the VP complement position, mirroring the position of the object in transitive verbs, as in (44c).

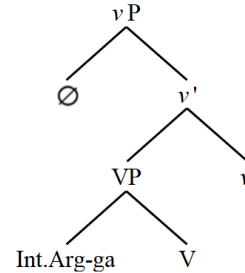
(44) a. transitive



b. unergative



c. unaccusative



In simple sentences, the outer argument is raised to subject position ([Spec, INFL]) and is simultaneously valued by tense. In an unaccusative verb structure, the internal argument obtains a nominative case and becomes the subject in a similar manner.

Since our analysis indicates that there is no agent argument in intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, we assume that the structure of intransitivizing *-te aru* is consistent with unaccusative verbs, but without raising of the internal argument, see (45a), suggesting that the structure should be as (45b).

- (45) a. Doa-**ga** ake-te aru.
 door-NOM open-*te aru*
 ‘The door has been opened.’

- b. [_{INFLP} [_{INFL}’ [_{AspP} [_{Asp}’ [_{VP} [_v’ [_{VP} doa-**ga** ake-te] v]] aru]] INFL]]

Specifically, as discussed in Section 3.1, the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration lacks a subject and the internal argument does not exhibit subject-like characteristics. This implies that the internal argument is not raised to the subject position, but remains within the *vP*. The location “*hondana*” (bookshelf) in (46a) and the indirect object “*hana*” (flower) in (46b) are both generated within VP, indicating that the initial position of the object is in the complement position within VP. Even if some movement is required afterwards, it can still be moved within *vP*, as in (47a) and (47b).¹³ As for the potential raising of the internal argument to the [Spec, AspP] position, further investigation is needed.

- (46) a. [_{VP} Hondana-ni syomotu-ga narabe-te]-aru.
 bookshelf-LOC books-NOM place-*te aru*
 ‘On the bookshelf, books have been placed.’

- b. [_{VP} Hana-ni mizu-ga yat-te]-aru.
 flower-DAT water-NOM water-*te aru*
 ‘The flowers have been watered.’

- (47) a. [_{VP} Syomotu-ga_i [_v’ [_{VP} hondana-ni t_i narabe-te] v]]-aru.
 books-NOM bookshelf-LOC place-*te aru*
 ‘Books have been placed on the bookshelf.’

- b. [_{VP} Mizu-ga_i [_v’ [_{VP} hana-ni t_i mai-te] v]]-aru.
 water-NOM flower-DAT water-*te aru*

¹³ In Miyagawa and Babyonishv’s (2004) analysis, the nominative object of intransitivizing *-te aru* moves out of VP, as in (3b) in the Introduction. Sugita’s (2009) and Kondo’s (2018) analyses, on the other hand, retain the nominative object within the VP, as in (6) and (10), respectively, in Section 2.1. In any case, we hold that the nominative object is retained within the *vP* phase.

‘Water is been watered for the flowers.’

Thus, the key question remained concerns how the object in intransitivizing *-te aru*, which is not raised to the subject position, can obtain nominative case in the same way as an unaccusative verb structure. This will be discussed in detail in the following section.

3.4 Nature of the nominative Case in the Intransitivizing *-te aru*

Up to now, little research has been conducted on how the object in the intransitivizing *-te aru* obtains a nominative case. Sugita (2009) suggest that under normal circumstances, the object cannot be assigned a nominative case, and thus obtains a default case. Kondo (2018) adopts Marantz’s (2000) morphological case theory, in which a noun can automatically acquire a nominative case when no other case can be assigned. In morphological case theory, nominative case is equal to the default case.

According to the analysis presented above, the intransitivizing *-te aru* configuration, shares similarities with the unaccusative structure and does not introduce agent argument. In principle, the nominative case (structural case) is assigned by T when a noun or determiner phrase is raised to the subject position. However, in both the intransitivizing *-te aru* and nominative object structures, the nominative noun remains unraised to the subject position.

Miyagawa and Babyonishev (2004) argue that T in intransitivizing *-te aru* does not possess the EPP feature, while Kondo (2018) suggests that in intransitivizing *-te aru* ν P/AspP lacks the EPP feature. In their systems, the object in intransitivizing *-te aru* cannot obtain nominative case from T, and the default case appears to be a plausible explanation.

Generally, in addition to the EPP feature, we also need to take the case feature into account. The case features on T (as Probe) and NP (as Goal) must be valued when transferred into the C-I system for interpretation. If tense feature locates on higher T rather than lower ν , the nominative case of the object will not be valued due to the Phase Impenetrability Condition (Chomsky 2008). Fortunately, according to Chomsky’s (2021: 34), we can assume that the tense feature is in ν rather than INFL. In this vein, the object can be assigned nominative case after it undergoes internal Merge to [Spec, ν P] (evaluation domain), rather than [Spec, INFL]. Notably, Chomsky (2015) argues that EPP can be reduced to the requirement of labeling, which allows us to dispense with the question of whether or not T carries EPP features.

role has also been deleted. This process occurs within the lexicon, hence there are no external arguments entering the syntactic operation. The syntactic structure after removing external arguments is similar to the nominative object structure of simple predicate. In addressing the nominative conundrum, we adopt Chomsky's (2021) idea—the tense feature is in the little v , by which the object in the intransitivizing *-te aru* can be assigned nominative case within vP . In this way, our discussion has thus far provided a cogent rationale for the absence of the agent argument and the presence of nominative case marking on the object in intransitivizing *-te aru* configurations.

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